[militant] traffic reports are not very positive." Meanwhile, the militants have shifted their geographical focus and are "now coming through Bangladesh with the help of Pakistani agencies. There has been a change in tactics but not a change in attitude."[7] As Indian defense analyst Raj Chengappa puts it, "We are not in a hair-trigger environment anymore. But the situation is still serious."[8]

Even if they have been modest, however, improvements in Indo-Pakistani relations are important, lowering the likelihood that major conflict will erupt between the two countries. Why have these changes occurred? To what extent have they resulted from nuclear deterrence? And what impact are nuclear weapons likely to have on Indo-Pakistani security relations in the future?

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In the aftermath of the 2001–2002 crisis, relations between India and Pakistan remained strained. However, the levels of infiltration from Pakistan into Kashmir declined.[9] Did the drop in infiltration result from India's exercise of coercive diplomacy? To this we have no clear-cut answer. It is certainly possible to surmise that the economic costs that India's massive deployment of firepower during Operation Parakram imposed on Pakistan coupled with American pressure led the military regime of General Musharraf to reevaluate its strategy of promoting terror in Kashmir.[10]

Despite this drop in infiltration, relations between India and Pakistan remained strained. Indeed not until February 2004 did the two sides agree to start a "composite dialogue" to address a range of outstanding bilateral issues, including the Kashmir question. They included discussions on conventional and nuclear confidence-building measures, the Siachen Glacier dispute, the Wullar/Tulbul Navigation Project, terrorism and drug trafficking, and the expansion of commercial and economic contacts.[11] These discussions proceeded apace to 2008 and made progress in a number of areas. Nevertheless, there was little substantive progress on the vexed question of Kashmir.